

What does a handoff cost a service desk?

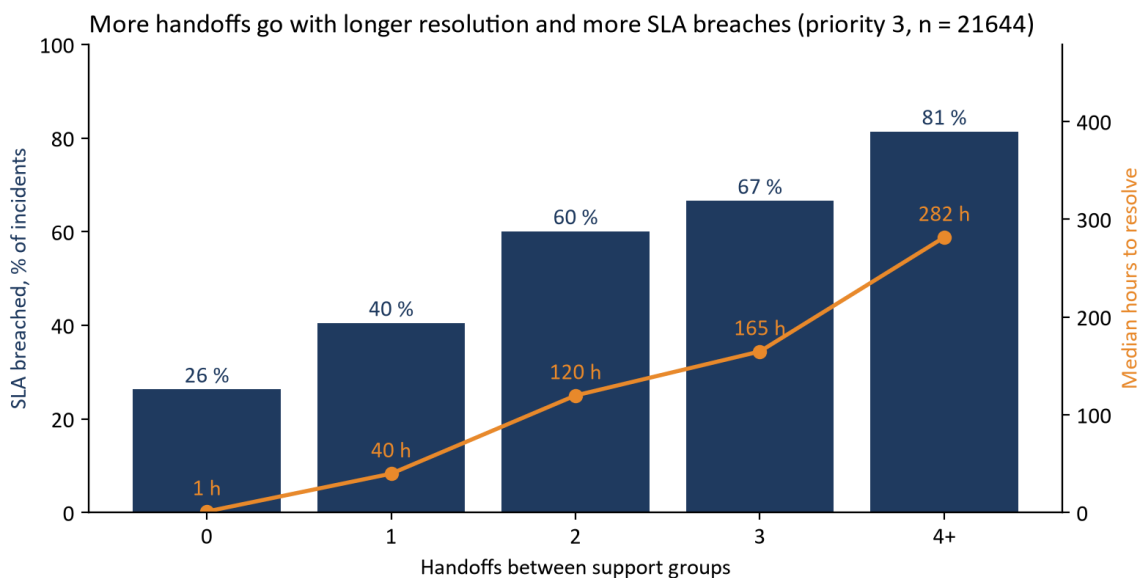
SQL analysis of a public IT incident log: 141 712 events, 24 918 incidents (ServiceNow export, UCI no. 498, CC BY 4.0). Personal project, October 2026.

QUESTION

How are handoffs between support groups related to resolution time and SLA breaches, and is ping-pong (a return to an earlier group) worse than a handoff to a new group?

WHAT I DID

Typed the raw event log and rebuilt, in SQL with window functions and CTEs, each incident's path through support groups. Compared medians and SLA breaches by number of handoffs (priority 3 only), compared ping-pong with forward-only paths at the same number of handoffs, wrote 11 SQL checks of incident-management process logic and data quality, and a reusable service desk KPI pack. Verified the headline numbers with an independent recount from the raw file.



RESULTS

- Solved by the first group: median 1 hour, SLA breached in 26 %. With 4 or more handoffs: 282 hours and 81 % (priority 3, 21 644 incidents with a recorded group).
- Ping-pong looks worse mainly because bounced incidents have more handoffs. At the same count the differences become small and are not consistent (2 handoffs: 60 % vs 60 % breached).
- The tool enforces its own logic (priority matrix, timestamps, SLA flag are clean), but 6.2 % of closed incidents carry no resolution time and drop out of reports based on it.

WHAT IT MEANS

First-group resolution goes with the shortest resolution times; getting incidents to the right group sooner looks more useful than forbidding returns; the resolution time should be mandatory at closure.

TOOLS

SQL (SQLite: window functions, CTEs), Python for loading and charts.